ERA 13

The New Imperialism

1867 – 1898

Why America looked outward · Hawaii · the great debate

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

Why did the United States abandon its tradition of isolation to build an overseas empire?

KEY TERMS

Mahan & sea power · Social Darwinism · the annexation of Hawaii · the Anti-Imperialist League

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 7.2 · AMSCO Ch. 7.2

FROM AN 'APART NATION' TO A WORLD POWER

Looking Outward

Why America Looked Outward

I

Economic

Industry needed new **markets** and **raw materials** to absorb its surplus.

II

Strategic

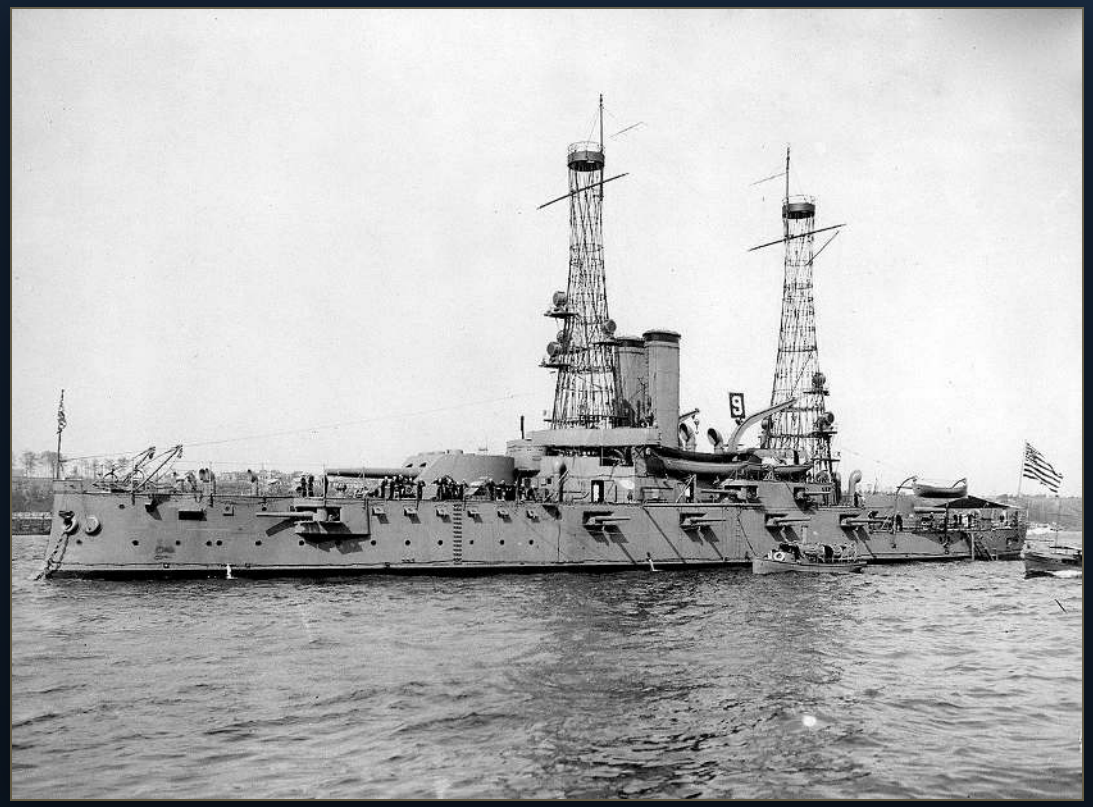
A world power needed a world-class **navy**—and overseas bases to fuel it.

III

Ideological

Social Darwinism, Anglo-Saxonism, and missionary zeal cast expansion as destiny.

Sea Power & the New Navy



- Naval officer **Alfred Thayer Mahan** argued in ***The Influence of Sea Power*** *Upon History* (1890) that great nations need great navies.
- The U.S. built a modern fleet of steel **battleships**.
- A powerful navy required coaling stations and bases—driving expansion.

First Footholds

1867

'Seward's Folly'

The U.S. buys **Alaska** from Russia—mocked, then vindicated.

1878

Samoa

America gains a Pacific naval station in the South Seas.

1887

Pearl Harbor

The U.S. leases the ideal Pacific naval port in **Hawaii**.

The Overthrow of Hawaii

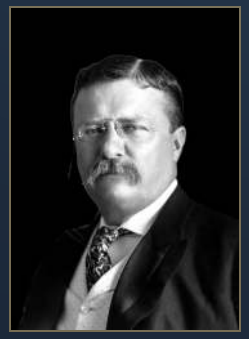
- American **sugar** planters dominated the islands' economy.
- In 1893, backed by U.S. troops, they overthrew **Queen Liliuokalani**.
- President **McKinley** completed the **annexation** of **Hawaii** in 1898.



SHOULD AMERICA HAVE AN EMPIRE?

The Great Debate

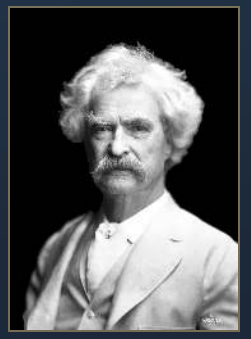
Imperialists vs. Anti-Imperialists



The Imperialists

For empire

- Empire brings **markets, power, and prestige**.
- A strong navy secures America's global standing.
- It is America's duty to 'civilize' and Christianize.

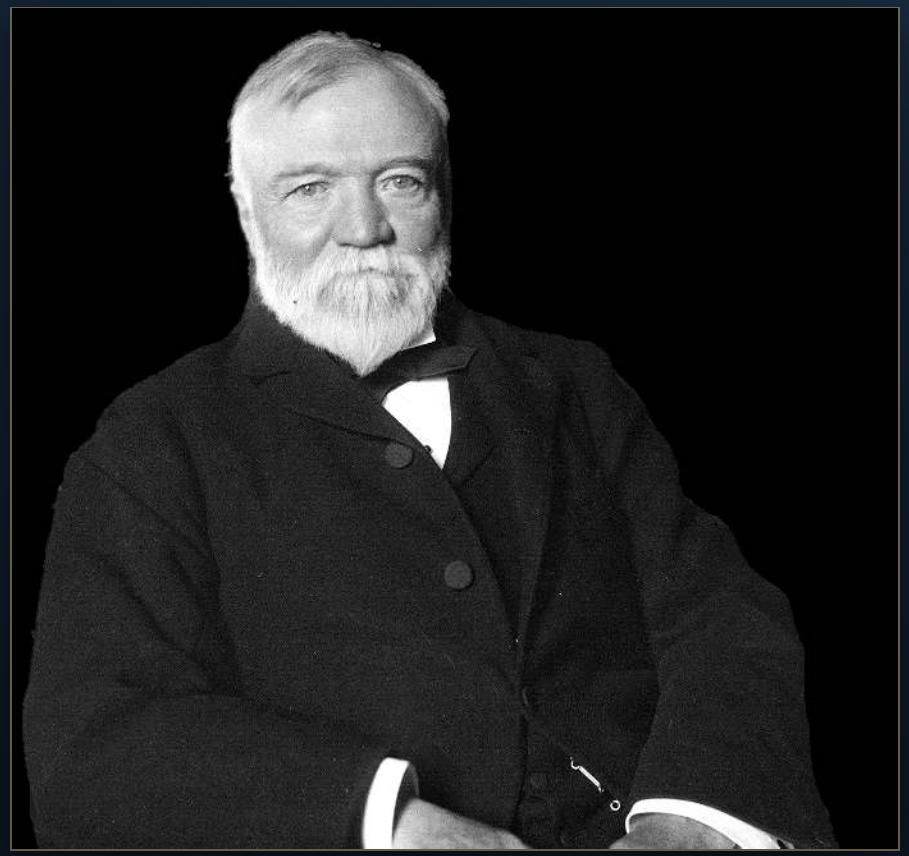


The Anti-Imperialists

Against empire

- Ruling others violates the **Declaration of Independence**.
- Empire betrays the principle of **self-determination**.
- Cheap colonial labor and goods threaten American workers.

The Anti-Imperialist League



- Founded in 1899, the **Anti-Imperialist League** fought U.S. expansion.
- Its unlikely coalition included **Andrew Carnegie**, **Mark Twain**, and Jane Addams.
- Though vocal, their voices were drowned out by the tide of empire.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The New Imperialism

1. **Economic, strategic, and ideological** forces—markets, **Mahan's navy**, and **Social Darwinism**—pushed America outward.

2. After footholds in **Alaska**, **Samoa**, **and Pearl Harbor**, the U.S. overthrew and annexed **Hawaii**.

3. A fierce **debate** pitted imperialists against the **Anti-Imperialist League** of Twain, Carnegie, and Addams.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The New Imperialism

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain the **economic, strategic, and ideological** forces that drove American expansionism.

COMPARISON

Compare the arguments of the **imperialists** and the **anti-imperialists**. Whose case was stronger?

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did overseas **imperialism** both extend and break from earlier **Manifest Destiny**?

Up next — **Class 37: The Spanish-American War & Empire** (America becomes a world power)